

Editorial

This year's *Leicestershire Historian* features a number of contrasting topics, whilst providing an insight into the wealth of material and artifacts in record offices, museums and elsewhere that is available to researchers.

A silver cup and a rare minute book enable Caroline Wessel to transport us behind the scenes into the world of 'The Club', an extraordinary fraternity of intelligent, successful and enquiring Victorian gentlemen, who met regularly in each others houses during the second half of the nineteenth century, indulging in sumptuous food, excellent and rare wines, and 'the spirit of generous and noble friendship'.

Half a century earlier, the prolific Leicester artist John Flower was producing large numbers of topographical sketches and watercolours. Recent work by Neil Finn on cataloguing the extensive collection of over 200 of Flower's works which are held at the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland, provides a new and well-illustrated assessment of historical significance of the artist's lesser known topographical works for Leicester and Leicestershire.

A remarkable figure in a different field was Dolly Shepherd, the pioneer Edwardian Parachute Queen, a regular visitor to North West Leicestershire, whose life and adventurous exploits are brought to life by Kenneth Hillier using source material and memorabilia from the Dolly Shepherd archive. Famous artistes and entertainers from an earlier period feature in J. D. Bennett's article on the history of Leicester's first purpose-built theatre. Later, as Leicester's public facilities developed, so did its capacity as a conference centre. In 1919, the new 'city' hosted the 54th Church Conference, the proceedings and the relationship with Leicester are described here by Gerald Rimmington.

2008 marks the 450th anniversary of the death of Hugh Aston, a remarkable early Tudor composer who settled in Leicester and made a significant contribution to the town's affairs. Patrick Boylan examines the actual identity of Aston, his association with the Newarke collegiate institution where he became director of music at St Mary's College, the role that Aston played in Leicester's civic life and the extent of his surviving compositions.

Jennifer Harris contributes a fascinating article on the history of Thurmaston through the development of its industries, notably framework knitting and the hosiery industry, the brick and tile works and basket-making, and how the community has tenaciously responded to change. Industrialisation also led to the demand for cheap public transport and in Leicester one of the responses to this was the development of the horse-drawn tram service which Lois Edwards helps us to discover more about through the lives of the tram horses. Meanwhile, goat-keeping in Leicestershire features in David Ramsey's article, along with what looks at first sight an unlikely connection with whetstones.

The case for a Wyvern town trail in Leicester is amply demonstrated by Celia Cotton in her fascinating article on the Wyvern in Leicester which identifies where to see all manner of Wyverns, along with their interesting historical connections. Cynthia Brown provides an interesting insight into the historical research methodology that she has been using on the Hands On History course at Vaughan College, where course members have been researching the centenary history of the Leicester Branch of the Workers Educational Association, making extensive use of the college's archives. Further afield, Bob Gibson examines a series of Leicestershire connections with the first permanent English settlement in North America, the Jamestown settlement of 1607 and the Virginia colony in the early years of the seventeenth century.

This edition contains the much-welcomed appearance of the listing of Local History and Heritage Groups in Leicestershire that Caroline Wessel has compiled, with the cooperation of the groups concerned.

2008 also sees a bumper Recent Publications section, and as always my grateful thanks go to John Hinks and his team of reviewers for this section which plays a vital role in keeping readers up-to-date.

The *Leicestershire Historian* aims to promote the study of the county's history by providing a platform for established and new authors, and through encouraging the pursuit of research and project work. It also aims to publicise the work of local groups and organisations, and seeks to raise the awareness of research sources.

Contributions for future editions are welcome from individuals, local groups, museums and other organisations and should be sent to the Editor for consideration. Articles can be short half-page items or longer in-depth pieces, and can be submitted at any time. If you would like to discuss an idea in advance, please contact the Editor.

Joyce Lee, Editor